

1660–1680

BONED BODICE TO MANTUA

The 20 years between 1660 and 1680 saw significant change in women's fashions and in society in general. In England King Charles II reclaimed the throne, while in France King Louis XIV established the Palace of Versailles, re-establishing the monarchy as the centre of patronage and high fashion. The evolution of women's clothing saw the slow demise of the dress made up of a boned bodice, a skirt, and gown, and the beginnings of the mantua, a loose gown with an overskirt elaborately draped at the back. New styles demanded different expertise, and women's dress was now made by mantua-makers, although more structured garments were still constructed by stay-makers and tailors. Women selected fabric and trimmings for dresses, including lace, from visiting drapers, linen and silk merchants, and milliners.

Riding clothes Women wore a particular type of clothing to travel on horseback in the 17th century. A "safeguard" was a loose skirt worn to keep off the dust, and there are also references to women wearing an early style of tailored jacket for riding.

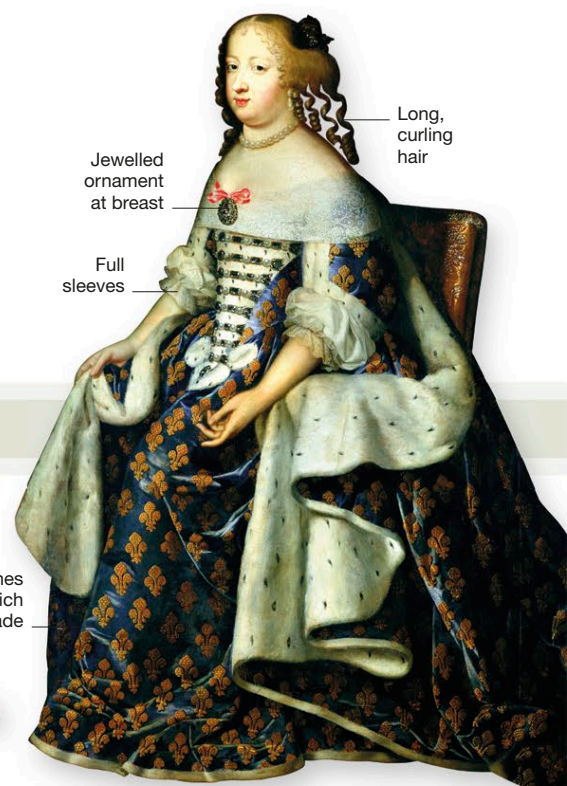
1660



Rigid bodice The distinctive round shape of women's dress in the 1660s was achieved by a tightly boned bodice with strips of whalebone inserted into finely stitched channels. Separate sleeves were tied to the garment at the shoulder.

Long, curling hair
Jewelled ornament at breast
Full sleeves

Clothes made of rich silk brocade

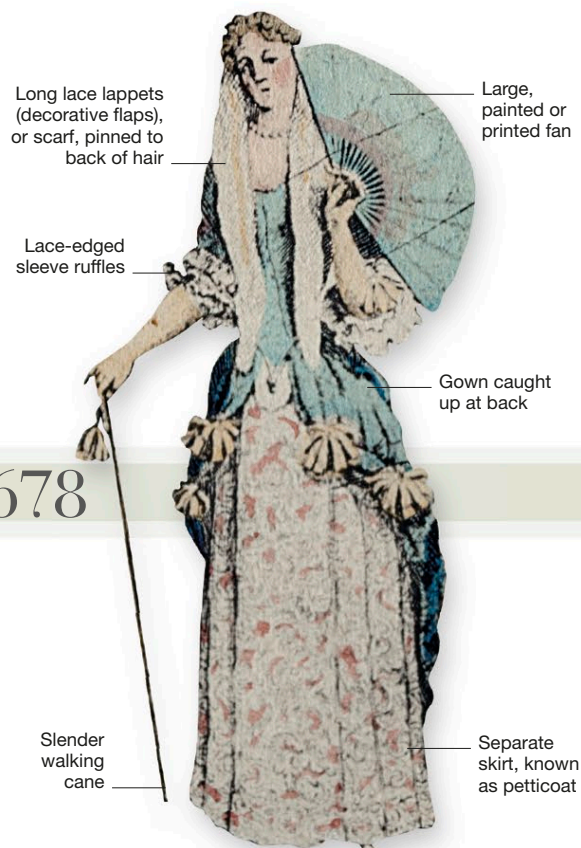


Royal gown Queen of France Marie-Thérèse (wife of Louis XIV) wears a boned bodice, and matching skirt and gown (edged with ermine) of the finest woven silk. Her deep collar is of exquisite, Flemish bobbin lace.

1675



1678



A new style During the 1670s a full-length gown was worn buttoned across the chest, and open below to reveal the petticoat. The skirts were caught up and draped at the back in a loose bustle arrangement.